

port, and the CPU vent. Boy, the latter does vent a lot of heat sometimes—might come in handy during the winters to warm your hands, I say :-)

The right-hand side of the laptop has one USB 2.0 port, besides the DVD writer drive. I would have preferred the other two USB ports to be available at this end too, rather than at the rear. Anyway, the rear also has an HDMI and a VGA port, besides the power connector and the Kensington lock. Seriously, it doesn't at all make sense to put anything at the back of a laptop, where plugging in cords or devices would mean flipping the laptop around. Ah! Well, I guess we're all usability-challenged!

Overall, I found the build quality quite rugged—and again, the 'chiclet' keyboard is a pleasure to use.

Oh, yes, here are the laptop's vital stats:

- CPU: Intel Core i3 330M @ 2.13 GHz
- Chipset: Intel HM55
- VGA: Intel GMA HD
- LCD size: 16:9 39.6-cm (15.6-inch) with a max resolution of 1366x768 pixels
- RAM: 4 GB DDR3 @ 1066 MHz
- HDD: Fujitsu 320GB SATA @ 5300RPM
- Webcam: 1.3 MP
- Card reader: SD/MMC/MS/XD
- Express Card slot
- Ethernet: Realtek RTL8101E/RTL8102E PCI express fast Ethernet controller
- WLAN: Atheros AR9285 wireless network adapter (PCI-Express)
- Bluetooth
- USB 2.0 ports: 3
- HDMI port: 1
- VGA port: 1
- Optical drive: DVD writer (Super-Multi)
- AC Adapter: 65W
- Keyboard: 103 keys, includes numeric keypad

...and feel

Well, with the specifications listed above, you expect good performance. My benchmarking includes the time it took to install Ubuntu 9.10 using a CD and a USB key; here are the figures:

- Install from CD: 10 minutes, 26 seconds
- Install from USB: 4 minutes, 37 seconds
- What about start-up and shut-down times?
- First boot after install (auto-login enabled): 33 seconds
- First shut-down: 3 seconds
- Subsequent boot time (auto-login enabled): 18 seconds
- Subsequent shut-down: 3 seconds

Note that these timings are recorded on a default install (with no additional services/packages installed) over an ext4 partition. Quite decent, I would say.

Next up is checking whether everything is working fine, using the System Testing tool—you can access it in Ubuntu from *System → Administration → System Testing*. I'm happy to note here that everything was detected as expected.

The CR620 has dimensions of 37.4x24.75x3.5 cm, which includes a 39.6 cm (15.6-inch) LCD display



When it comes to overall performance, the system showed no sign of lag or screen redraw/refresh issues, while multitasking with Compiz Fusion features activated to their full glory. The load average stayed below 1 whenever I checked, although sometimes the CPU vented out some heat—how I wished I had this laptop during the Delhi winters.

Using the webcam and mic was as easy as starting a video call (over Google Talk) using Empathy. Simply initiate a video call, and the webcam is automatically activated.

The most important parameters for laptops are obviously suspend to RAM (sleep) and disk (hibernate). And I'm happy to report that the system woke up without any issues, every time. As for battery life: on average, it lasted for 3 hours without requiring the AC adapter to be plugged in, under a normal workload—Amarok playing some tunes, Firefox (with around 10 tabs open, including YouTube), OpenOffice.org Writer, file manager, a few terminal sessions installing packages on and off, etc. Although the HP 550 laptop also sported 3 hours of battery life to begin with, it went down to a mere 10 minutes within 8 months of regular usage. So only time will tell how durable the CR620 battery turns out to be.

Verdict?

This is a must-buy, if you're looking for a hassle-free laptop with average specs and at a decent price. Oh—I haven't mentioned the price tag yet, have I? Rs 34,999 with a warranty of two years.

The downside? For that price you would have paid the lame Windows tax, and got the Windows 7 sticker stuck on the surface for free. What? Did I hear you say you want it without Windows, at a lower price? Well, so do I! :-)



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The author likes to headbang to rock n' roll tunes, and considers himself an apt air guitarist.